

STAGE THREE • JOB APPLICATION & INTERVIEW SKILLS

FIRSTS

FAQ

Anticipated participant questions and suggested facilitator responses

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

BY AYOMIDE AYENI

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PURPOSE

These are the questions that come up most often across cohorts of Stage Three, with a suggested facilitator response for each. Use these as a starting point, not a rigid script.

Frequently Asked Questions

Q1. What if I've applied to dozens of jobs and heard back from almost none of them?

A: That's genuinely common and usually says more about the volume-over-strategy approach than about you as a candidate. This stage is specifically about building a more targeted, tailored strategy — fewer, better-matched applications tend to outperform many generic ones.

Q2. Is it actually okay to negotiate a first offer, especially for an entry-level role?

A: Yes, respectfully and with real research behind it. Most first offers have some built-in room, and a polite, well-reasoned counter rarely damages an employer's enthusiasm for a candidate they've already decided to hire.

Q3. What if I completely blank during a real interview, even after all this practice?

A: It happens to almost everyone at some point. Your Interview Mindset Routine (FIRST C15) is specifically designed for this — a brief pause, a breath, and a return to your prepared structure usually gets you back on track faster than panicking.

Q4. How many jobs should I realistically be applying to per week?

A: This varies by field and market, but the Application Strategy exercise (FIRST C2) is designed to help you find your own realistic, sustainable number rather than following a generic universal target. Quality of match matters more than raw volume.

Q5. What if I get a real offer and I'm not sure if it's actually good?

A: That's exactly what the Offer Comparison Matrix (FIRST C20) is for — bring your real numbers and factors to that exercise, and don't hesitate to also talk it through privately with your facilitator or a trusted mentor.

Q6. Do I really need to send a thank-you email after every single interview, even ones that went badly?

A: Yes — FIRST C16 frames this specifically as a habit, not a reaction to how you think it went. You're often not the best judge of how an interview actually landed, and the habit itself builds a reputation for professionalism regardless of outcome.

Q7. What if a company's assessment or technical interview format is completely unfamiliar to me?

A: Research the specific company's known format in advance where possible (forums, alumni, or employees can help), and focus your practice on timed, realistic conditions rather than assuming all assessments are the same. FIRST C13 covers this directly.